It started small. Six girls in their mid-teens, in the coastal Karnataka town of Udupi, were refused permission by their pre-university college (PUs are the equivalent of Plus 2) to don the hijab in class. The truth here comes in many versions but essentially the dispute dates to the monsoon semester of 2020. The girls had just joined as freshers. They wore normal clothes, hijab included, for a few days before everyone bought their uniforms. They sought permission to retain their headscarves over and above it, but in vain—the hijabs had to come off for class. Something sacred for them, how to comport oneself in public, was being violated in public.

A fuzziness covers the rules that enabled the college to trespass onto individual rights thus. It had had a uniform since 2004, but with no written guidelines, certainly no word about things proscribed. (Indeed, Karnataka has a history of allowing an exception for the hijab since Ramakrishna Hegde's time in the 1980s). More importantly, the college's uniform rule rested on rather grey statutory footing. The Karnataka Education Act, 1983—the parent act governing these state pre-university colleges—does not mandate it. Subsequent rules passed under the Act, in 1995, allowed institutions to devise their own rules, including uniforms, with no mandatory clause—confounding the trail with a seeming contradiction. A 2014 circular then brought in a new element: College Development Committees. Anyway, the uniform rule was not very strictly followed, from most accounts, till recent years—roughly coinciding with the time the present MLA, Raghupati Bhat, came to chair the college's CDC.

The second wave put the whole thing in hibernation, along with every other aspect of public life, till the college reopened in October—and the girls renewed their demand. The fahrenheit levels picked up in right earnest around December 29, when the girls started protesting outside the college gates. Initially, a piece of news so minor that it took a month for it to reach even the Bangalore press. But by February, the whole landscape was lit up like a landmine-strewn conflict zone. And it produced a conflagration so huge, in the highly inflammable air of India's political and social life, that the heat could be felt across the country's vast landmass, even beyond.

It was not an equal battle, but exhibited all the crests and troughs of an epic one. From local news, it first migrated to the front pages with intimidating counter-protests by throngs of saffron-wearing male students from colleges in the vicinity. A month into their protest, the girls approached the Karnataka High Court—their desire to wear the attire of their choice was protected under various fundamental rights, they said. It is a noble list: the Right to Equality (Article 14), to Freedom (Art.

A Cover Story

The terms may be used interchangeably, but in fact, the *hijab*, *niqab* and *burqa* are different pieces of Islamic covering, though all designed to protect a woman's modesty. They have in recent years sparked debate around the world, with some militating against this show of religious identity, and others seeing it as a patriarchal imposition on women's bodies, cloaking them in victimhood, and depriving them of choice and agency. The Muslim woman herself is divided: with one half of the sorority discarding it and the other half embracing it as an observation of their faith. But, first, what is the hijab, and its cousins?



GETTY IMAGES

Hijab

The simplest covering, this is essentially a length of cloth used to cover the head and neck, much like the ***ghoonghat*** among Hindu women, who often use the end of the sari to cover their head

Niqab

A starker covering, the *niqab* veils the face and covers the head and neck, but leaves the eyes exposed

